California passes law allowing residents to recover possessions looted by Nazis

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California Gov. Gavin Newsom signed Assembly Bill (AB 2867) into law, enabling California residents to recover art and personal belongings stolen during the Holocaust, his office announced on Monday.

The bill was introduced following a ruling by the Ninth Circuit Court of Appeals, which allowed a Spanish museum to retain possession of a painting stolen from the Cassirer family by the Nazis during the Holocaust.

The bill is aimed to ensure that California law applies in lawsuits related to the theft of artwork or property during the Holocaust or other acts of persecution.

“For Holocaust survivors and their families, the fight to reclaim art and other personal items stolen by the Nazis continues to reopen traumatic wounds,” said Gov. Newsom. “It is both a moral and legal imperative to return these valuable and sentimental pieces to their rightful owners. I am proud to strengthen California’s laws to help secure justice for these families.”

Assembly member Jesse Gabriel praised the governor’s decision, stating, “Governor Newsom’s signature on this bill is a victory for morality and justice, ensuring that California stands on the right side of history. AB 2867 will empower Holocaust survivors and other victims of persecution to reclaim stolen property, sending a clear message to those who refuse to return stolen art.”

“I applaud Governor Newsom for his long-standing leadership in supporting Holocaust survivors and thank him for his partnership on this important new law,” Gabriel added.

Present at the bill-signing event were Guy Lipa, grandson of Holocaust survivors and board chair of Holocaust Museum LA; Daniel Gryczman, grandson of Holocaust survivors and board vice chair of the LA Jewish Federation; and Beth Kean, CEO of Holocaust Museum LA.

David Cassirer, a member of the family seeking the return of stolen art, commented, “California, through AB 2867, has drawn a clear line, enabling families like ours to recover priceless works and protecting the rights of all victims of stolen art, including Holocaust survivors and their descendants.”

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